Fiche professeur

Passing the Flame. Othello, or the trap of theatrical illusion.

Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac

Tle spécialité LLCER · lycée général et technologique · Level C1

Programme of BO spécial n° 8 of 25 July 2019: thematic areas « Arts et débats d'idées » and « Expression et construction de soi » (axis « Mise en scène de soi »). Level C1.

Each ordinary lesson lasts 55 minutes and is timed on 52, with a stopping point and an eight-minute emergency exit. The midpoint commentary follows Lesson 5. Lesson 10 is the summative hour.

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Teacher's sheet, in English, for a C1 sequence in Tle spécialité LLCER (lycée général et technologique).

Guiding question. How does Shakespeare turn theatre itself into a trap of perception in *Othello*, and what does that trap still teach us about language, jealousy and the courage to read between the lines?

Ten lessons of 55 minutes, timed on 52, with a stopping point at minute 44 and an eight-minute emergency exit. Midpoint after Lesson 5. Summative in Lesson 10.

British English throughout. The student booklet now prints complete speeches, with line numbers (Gutenberg 1531) and short glosses. Ask the class to read the extract first, in silence or aloud, before any commentary. Do not paraphrase the verse in advance.

How to run the sequence

- Open each lesson on the **Before you read** question. Then the extract. Then the numbered tasks.
- Keep model close readings closed until students have tried.
- Homework is short and reuses the day's language.
- The spirale de Gorse is the method, not a decoration. Return to the day's turn on the board.
- Video essay (Lesson 1): five minutes, once. Do not replace looking at Chassériau.

Before the first lesson

- A public-domain text of *Othello* (Gutenberg 1531) and, if possible, a Folger print or digital text for classroom line numbers.
- François-Victor Hugo, *Othello ou le More de Venise*, public domain, for Lesson 9.
- The video essay and the Chassériau image (Louvre, RF 3897).
- No modern critical monograph to be photocopied. Name later critics if useful; do not quote them at length.

Lesson by lesson: intention, pitfalls, board, emergency exit

Lesson 1. Inheriting a way of reading

Intention. Look first. The painting is not an illustration of the plot.

Pitfall. Biography of Carole, or of Shakespeare, eating the hour. The dedication is read; it is not a lesson on the teacher.

Board. *I can see… / This cannot prove…*

Emergency exit. Four sentences on the painting only.

Lesson 2. « I am not what I am »

Intention. The last line is a contract with the spectator, not a psychological label.

Pitfall. « Iago is evil. » Stay in the speech: shows, seeming, inversion.

Board. Three movements of the speech; the words of the mask.

Emergency exit. Four sentences (student booklet).

Lesson 3. The Senate

Intention. A tale that wins a hearing; a warning that plants a future.

Pitfall. Reducing the wonders (Anthropophagi, antres) to « exotic colour ». They are part of the proof.

Board. Fact of service / travellers' wonders / Desdemona's listening. Then the chiasmus. Then Brabantio.

Emergency exit. Tale, chiasmus, planted warning, pledge.

Lesson 4. The desire for proof

Intention. Mark the shift from « I'll know thy thoughts » to a proof with « no hinge nor loop ».

Pitfall. A general speech on jealousy. The metaphor of the monster must be read, not only named.

Board. To know / to be confirmed. *Ocular proof*.

Emergency exit. The four-sentence frame in the booklet.

Lesson 5. III.4, mandatory close reading

Intention. Three trusts, one object, a method already installed in III.3. The speeches are printed whole.

Pitfall. « It is only a handkerchief. » That is Rymer's sarcasm, to be answered later, not adopted now. Also: do not invent Othello's off-page childhood to explain the Egyptian tale. Argue from the verse.

Board. Emilia's lie; moist hand; curse-narrative; « what and if »; self-begotten monster.

Emergency exit. The four moves in the booklet.

Midpoint. Timed commentary on III.4, next hour or the second half of a double period if you have one. Grid below.

Lesson 6. Directing the spectator

Intention. IV.1 as a directed looking. Students must keep three positions: Cassio, Iago, Othello.

Pitfall. Laughing with Cassio and losing Othello; or pitying Othello and losing the mechanism.

Board. Three-column table (hears / is about / has been prepared).

Emergency exit. The four-clause frame in the booklet.

Lesson 7. One conversation, two meanings

Intention. A precise map, not a second first reading.

Pitfall. Retelling Lesson 6. The new work is the score (four columns) and the words *referent* / *assigned story*.

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Board. One Cassio line, two hearings.

Emergency exit. Three facts and one quotation.

Lesson 8. The language of justification

Intention. Rhetoric at the bed, then the last self-portrait. Both speeches whole.

Pitfall. Moral summary (« he is wrong to kill her »). True, and not yet a reading. Stay with *cause*, the turned *light*, « Speak of me as I am ».

Board. Justice words / tenderness words. Then the portraits in the last speech.

Emergency exit. The five-clause frame in the booklet.

Lesson 9. Critics and Hugo

Intention. Answer a critic; study a translation choice. Hugo only.

Pitfall. Name-dropping later critics as authorities. A short name is enough. The work is Rymer, Johnson, Coleridge, Hazlitt, Bradley, and the verse.

Board. What he sees / what he misses / a line that answers him.

Emergency exit. Rymer only, via Lesson 5.

Lesson 10. Summative

Intention. A commentary that explains the trap without closing the play by force.

Pitfall. A paraphrase of the plot, or a sermon on rumour in society with no verse.

Board. The question, the expected shape, the emergency exit (IV.1 only).

Oral. Director's commentary: one space, one address or silence, one refusal, each from the verse.

Marking grids (teacher's copy)

Midpoint (III.4) and summative (Lesson 10), each /20, indicative.

Criterion	Points	A strong script
Thesis	4	Precise, arguable, not a plot summary.
Text	5	Accurate quotation, used, located.
Devices	4	Named and shown at work.
Argument	4	Parts that move; a close that opens.
Language	3	Controlled C1 British English; cautious verbs.

The oral director's task may be marked separately, /10: space (3), address or silence (3), a justified refusal (3), language (1).

Differentiation

The emergency exit is for a student in difficulty at minute 44, not a second lower sequence. Stronger students may take the optional Hugo passage (the moist-hand speech) and the optional III.3 soliloquy in Lesson 4. The accessible version is a set of autonomous fiches, not a reduced demand.

What not to do

- Do not cut the printed extracts in class. They are meant to be worked on whole, with glosses.
- Do not photocopy modern criticism.
- Do not use any French translation other than Hugo.
- Do not treat Chassériau as a snapshot of a scene in the play.

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- Do not skip III.4.

Credit and method

Méthode de la spirale de Gorse conçue par Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac.

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